

[P6 - Frank] CEO

SI 501 - K018F: Interview Protocol for Talent Guard

Protocol

[Introduction]

Hi, my name is [*Yiru and I'll be conducting the bulk of the interview*], and this is [*Tori; she'll be taking notes but may potentially also chime in to ask questions here and there*] – we're master's students at the University of Michigan School of Information. As you hopefully have heard, my class is doing a consulting project with TalentGuard. We are here to understand better how TalentGuard employees and clients think about Talent Guard's talent assessment software and see how it might be improved. This interview will take about 45 minutes, during which time we'll go through some questions, and I might ask you to show me how you actually conduct your work. Throughout, I'd like you to treat me as if you're describing the situation to someone who isn't familiar with the software or even with TalentGuard. I'm here to learn from you.

A couple of things before we start. To the extent possible, we will take your comments to be confidential. We will aggregate all the comments from the six interviews we're conducting so that your comments are not easily traced to you. If we quote you in our final report, we will do so without identifying your name or specific role. If there's anything you really don't want on the record, even if it's anonymous, please let me know that, too. Also, this interview is entirely voluntary on your part – if for any reason you want to stop, please let me know. We can end the interview at that point with no repercussions for you of any kind. If you wish, I can also throw out my notes of what you've told me until that point.

We were hoping to record this interview for transcription purposes. How would you feel most comfortable recording? Could we use the recording function on Zoom, or prefer if we just take an audio recording? This is just so that my team doesn't miss anything – no one at your organization or otherwise will have access to the recording. [*Wait for response.*] Thanks.

Commented [ZY1]: It was smooth in this recording process.

Do you have any questions for me? All right, then, let's proceed.

Interview Questions: Visionaries

[Overarching Question]

- What do you think are the current pain points for users or the barriers between potential users and the TalentGuard skill management product? How do you envision TalentGuard's product shaping the future of talent assessment?

[Warm-Up]

- How long have you been working at TalentGuard?
 - Since the beginning, is the cofounder-10 yrs now
- What does your job entail? Can you walk me through what a typical day looks like for you?
 - Title- cofounder, cto, primary responsibility is with products
 - Joy works for him, UX design team, engineers, tech writing
 - All product related functions work for him
 - End of day he is responsible for building right product, making it highest value possible
- Do you ever personally use the software? What aspects of the software are you most familiar with? Can you walk me through them?
 - Familiar with most
 - Original architect, original programmer
 - Many hands have touched it
 - They are very small, 40(?) employees
 - Designed for large companies/enterprise
 - They want to start using some aspects internally
 - Very interested in using the development plan internally AND talent assessment internally—a small company could sue these, but not target market
 - Not thinking about small company when designing

Commented [ZY2]: The interviewee sounded very proud. And it sounds to me that he wish I didn't ask this question and I have already done the research before interviewing him.

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[Workflow]

- What are some good elements for a good workflow for a skill management tool?
 - [Follow up, if they don't include in their response]
 - Create your job architecture—an or can have many jobs made of man skills made of man proficiency levels
 - Complex model that tries to capture many things
 - Complex architecture
 - They offer a taxonomy that can be offered from day one
 - Rarely find that customers are happy with taxonomy as it is, want to customize it
 - Jobs are being refreshed, coming in and going away, constant change has to be managed
 - System helps to keep up to date and manage that complexity [of jobs coming and going away]

- Everything is built on that foundation—when they onboard customers, it's not about training how to use the software, but it's about the job architecture
- What you don't want to do is do a shoddy job of the job architecture—don't want wrong skills being deployed
- Once it's deployed, the ideal first thing an employee will do is job assessment*****
- When you look at each skill, there are several proficiency levels; when you start a career, the assumption is that you will begin at the baseline proficiency level
- There may be 10-15 statements you can look at as a manager to see if you are meeting to check if you are meeting a given proficiency level
- After you go through the assessment, you identify the gaps to see what is missing
- Once the gaps are identified, we can assign learning resources—it could be an experience you need to gain—becomes part of development plan
- “Those all move to my development plan”
- Now that your assessment is done “you have a good understanding of your apps”
- We will identify the intermediate steps you need to take—machine learning engineer 1, 2, 3 etc
- What we found was most people don't look very much beyond for the next role
- I can scan my organization for everybody who fits that role, and it's going to rank order everybody who fits that role; I can ID those individuals and reach out to those individuals; I can tell them they're not quite there but [can effectively help to cultivate them for specific roles]
- Can you walk me through the specifics of why these things make a good workflow?
- What features of TalentGuard software exemplify good workflow?
- Can you explain to me what your understanding of a “skill” is? Can you provide an example or two?
 - [Follow up, if they don't include in their response]
 - Why is this how you define “skill”?
 - How is this understanding of “skill” incorporated into the software?
 - Something you need to do your job successfully
 - Soft skills (common across many jobs) and hard skills
 - Technical skills—you know how to write a program, for example Python
 - Can be broad and general, a capability you need, or something specific and very very technical
 - SOMETIMES I USE SKILL AND CAPABILITY INTERCHANGEABLY*****
 - Y*****
 - The way I think about it is a technical person—it's a few things I need to do the job successfully, they range from general things to very specific things

Commented [ZY3]: This is where the CEO talks on and on. We should ask him to stick to our question and rambling less

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Commented [ZY4]: This is quite different from what we heard from some other interviewees

- Starts with self-assessment, then the manager looks at each one and decides whether they agree or not, more of an agree or disagree flow—they could agree because of underrating—you are higher than u say.
 - Manager feels employee has rated too highly, employee is a level below—triggers a convo—could be done through a dialogue online or done in person
 - Doesn't affect employee's performance because it's not a performance review
 - Aiming for a “nice, chatty” dialogue
 - Vision for future: another level of validation
 - Lowest level: opinion of self
 - Next level: manager
 - 3rd level: external assessment: a test that people can take (ex. I can code in python—take a test in python, get a score)
 - Skills as a currency where the value increases with the level of validation
 - Develop employees into a better version of themselves
 - Not meant to affect salary
 - Not performance appraisal
 - What it is: set ppl up for promotion, move them into different roles: NOT PERFORMANCE
- Have you heard any alternate interpretations of “skill”? Since they do not match your definition, why are these incorrect, in your opinion?
- What is competency?
 - How does a competency differ from a skill?
 - How are competencies integrated into TalentGuard?
 - Why does the distinction matter?
 - Between competencies and skills, which is more meaningful?
 - If forced to choose between one or the other, which do you choose? Why?
 - When discussing TalentGuard, what are the three most important topics to consider? Just three things that must be discussed? Why?
 - [Generate follow up questions on the fly]
 - Can you walk me through your ideal use case for the TalentGuard software?
 - [Follow up, if they don't include in their response]
 - Step-by-step, how do you anticipate a user to experience your product?
 - Where does a user encounter difficulties?
 - 3 separate things; things feel separate even though they are connected; identifying gaps, learning options, development plan—a user has to realize they need to go somewhere completely different, for ex. To look at career paths, development plans
 - Not always obvious to the user that there is a path/flow to follow

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Commented [ZY5]: This question sounds redundant because the interviewee had already touched on the question early on

- Talent assessment is not a clear starting point
- Explanations are currently required; documents, books, and videos are required to understand where to start
- Modules:
 - Used to be a la carte modles
 - Now they are sold in bundles, logically related
 - 3-4 bundle options
 - Core bundle is talent framework, job architecture, intelligent role studio, talent assess, dev plan, career path
 - Enterprise bundle: above stuff, plus succession plan/talent mobility planning
 - They deploy the modules in chunks (?) to mitigate the extant problem of users not knowing what order to use modules
 - The deployment is limited to a smaller portion of the org, resulting in a limited number of the company seeing the deployment order
 - New users are lost and unsure of where to start
 - New users must rely on ongoing, continued training
 - Product is not designed to be used every day
 - People forget how to use TG because large periods of time elapse between usages (1, 2, 3 months)
 - Goals: avoid repeated training
- What are the pain points in your opinion?
 - Lost
 - New users are lost and unsure of where to start
 - Mentions maybe arrows are helpful, but also annoying—not a fan of excessive prompts
 - Missing a proper homepage; modules were present in the form of big blocks
 - Required users to simply know information
 - Now there's a homepage that provides high-level overview of what's going on in each module & small reminder
 - New problem: once oyu leave the homepage, you have to remember to go back to the homepage
- Why do these pain points exist?
- How did you come to the above conclusions?
- When was the last time TalentGuard redefined its mission?
 - Can you walk me through TalentGuard's mission? Its goals?
 - How well are the goals being fulfilled?
 - What changes have you instigated to help see these missions through to fulfillment?

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Commented [ZY6]: Although the interviewee sees the interface to be confusing, the firm still keep complexing the home page on their latest update

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- Can you walk me through the last major update of the TalentGuard software? What are some major changes?
 - [\(The Home Page\)](#)
 - Why are these changes/decisions made? Could you please walk me through your thoughts when making these decisions?
 - How have these changes affected the user experience?
- Where do you see TalentGuard in five years?
 - How does TalentGuard get there?
 - How aligned is your perspective with the overall organizational perspective?
 - [Wants to be an industry leader in skilling, up, and re-skilling solutions](#)
 - [Employee engagement, retention are also important; believes employees are more engaged and greater retention if they are more able to take control of their own career + development](#)
 - [Empower employees to take control of their career destiny](#)
 - [Employee empowerment—not managers*****](#)
 - [They want to facilitate employees' ability to move around companies, closing gaps, eliminate as much of managers' control](#)
 - [Focus on things that matter, don't waste time on things that don't](#)
 - [Good feeling when software helps someone who is lost find their way](#)
- What distinguishes TG from others?
 - [Many ppl validate, but it's insufficient to create the experience he wants and is more aligned with performance—more of a screening tool, doesn't develop](#)
 - [They use it to close gaps, and it doesn't prevent anything—it's purely for growth](#)
- How do you feel clients could be given more ownership of the assessment process?
 - What do you think is limiting client buy-in?
 - How do you think you can increase client buy-in?

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Commented [ZY7]: This is a great question for CEO, but not necessary for the rest of the employees based on my observation and replaying the recordings

Commented [ZY8]: The note taker is trying really hard, but the interviewee is not providing very valuable information

[Improvement]

- What changes would you like to see made in TalentGuard?
 - What changes would you prioritize? And why did you make those priorities?

[Conclusion]

Those are all the questions we have for you. If anything else occurs to you after we leave, please don't hesitate to let me know by email at quartetconsulting@umich.edu. We may be in touch with you again to ask a few follow-up questions. And, in about 6-8 weeks, after we've concluded all the interviews and our analysis, we will send you our final report, which will also be provided to your organization. We're also scheduled to do a presentation, and I believe you will be invited to that. Thanks again!

Reflection | Yiru Zhang

I am the interviewer of this session. Our interview was scheduled for 45 minutes, but it went longer and ended after about an hour. I find the timing is quite important. Because when we wrote our protocol, we didn't think or estimate how long our interview would actually be based on the questions we had. And also, the timing is based on the interviewee's job role, personality, and familiarity with their product. And I find that when I was interviewing, I constantly look at the clock to see if I still have enough time to ask all my questions, or if I have to skip a few and move on to the more important ones, or more related ones. I think in the future, the interview protocol could probably be rated into different priorities so that if we are short on time, we could skip the relatively less important ones and go straight to the crucial ones. Overall, I find this interview to be smooth and meaningful. CEO Frank is very responsive, and he answers all questions if not more. Also, this interviewee is very willing to talk to us about their product, problems, and pain points. However, there are still places that I wish I could have done better in accuracy, interruption, and better preparation. First, I wish I could be more concise and accurate in what I am asking for. There are a few questions that I find a little overlapping which I didn't notice until the interview. So I had to reorganize my language and ask questions that are not very accurate. But the interviewee could understand my questions most of the time. Secondly, since the interviewee is very excited about our help with their product, he tends to talk on and on and on. It is very hard to move forward with our interview efficiently. In my next interview, I will try to interrupt his talking and guide the interviewee back to the track that we planned. And that will save us time on more valuable answers and questions. In this interview, we ended up skipping a few questions in the middle. Last but not least, we will need better preparation for the interview. The protocol is good, but could still be better. Since we adjusted the protocols based on each job role, there are still slight differences when it comes to the specific interview. I think rehearsal would help to make the questions connected and also tease out duplicated or redundant questions.